Project Statement: Race, Sport & Social Equity: Transatlantic Perspectives from US HBCUs and South African HDIs

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Host Institution: University of the Western Cape (SRES)
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1. Project Rationale

Sport serves as a powerful lens through which societal issues of race, class, and inequality are both reflected and contested. In the United States and South Africa, institutions historically marginalized by racial policies, specifically Historically Black Colleges and Universities (HBCUs) and Historically Disadvantaged Institutions (HDIs), have played pivotal roles in advancing social change. Yet, both continue to encounter profound structural barriers in resource allocation, athletic governance, and leadership representation.

While a robust body of scholarship examines athletic governance within well-resourced, mainstream institutions, there is a critical lack of comparative, transatlantic scholarship examining how marginalized institutions navigate state policies and resource constraints to drive equitable governance.

This project bridges that gap by connecting Johnson C. Smith University (JCSU) in Charlotte, NC, with the Department of Sport, Recreation and Exercise Science (SRES) at the University of the Western Cape (UWC) in Cape Town, South Africa. As South Africa actively measures sport transformation through the National Sport and Recreation Plan and national equity audits, pairing an HBCU with an HDI establishes a vital, real-time comparative framework.

This project is needed to:

- Analyze how historical disenfranchisement shapes modern sport governance and access.
- Bridge the gap between U.S. and South African classrooms, offering undergraduate students exposure to global comparative policy.
- Provide community sport organizers with actionable data to improve youth access to athletic infrastructure.

2. Project Objectives

Operating across three integrated pillars, the project's objectives are:

- **Research:** Examine and compare sport governance structures, equity initiatives, and policy impacts at JCSU (NCAA Division II) and UWC, utilizing the Sports Policy Factors Leading to International Sporting Success (SPLISS) framework.
- **Teaching:** Develop and co-deliver a 6-week Collaborative Online International Learning (COIL) module connecting JCSU's SPM 435 (Sport Sociology) and UWC's SRE 743 (Sociology of Sport) to internationalize the classroom.
- **Community Engagement:** Partner with local sport stakeholders, specifically the Cape Flats youth organization Play Sport4Life (PS4L), to translate academic governance theory into community-driven social impact.

3. Research Design and Methodology

This project adopts a mixed-methods convergent parallel design that combines empirical qualitative inquiry, quantitative survey metrics, and participatory ethnography. The methodology is designed to be highly feasible within the 6-month grant period.

Qualitative Inquiry ($N \approx 30$ Participants)

- **Semi-Structured Interviews ($N = 15$ per institution):** Conducted with senior athletic directors, compliance officers, and policymakers at JCSU and UWC to evaluate institutional equity strategies and barriers to resource acquisition.
- **Documentary Analysis:** Systematic policy review of NCAA/HBCU governance documents, UWC university athletic handbooks, and South Africa's National Sport and Recreation Plan using reflexive thematic analysis (NVivo).

Quantitative Metrics ($N \approx 200$ Responses)

- **Cross-Institutional Equity Surveys:** Distributed to student-athletes and sports management students at JCSU ($n \approx 100$) and UWC ($n \approx 100$). The survey will measure perceived resource distribution, leadership diversity, and the impact of equity policies using a validated 5-point Likert scale.
- **Statistical Analysis:** Descriptive statistics and independent-samples t-tests (SPSS) will be used to compare student perception metrics across the HBCU and HDI contexts.

Participatory Fieldwork

- **Community Focus Groups:** Facilitating focus groups with Cape Flats community stakeholders alongside Play Sport4Life (PS4L) to capture lived experiences regarding grassroots athletic access.

4. The COIL Transatlantic Exchange

A core component of this Fulbright is teaching. UWC's SRE 743 (Sociology of Sport) and JCSU's SPM 435 (Sport Sociology and Ethics) possess substantial thematic overlap regarding the sociology of race, gender, and class in sport.

- **Pedagogical Alignment:** SRE 743′s units on multicultural society and social research align perfectly with SPM 435′s curriculum on race and ethnicity in sport.
- **Delivery Format:** Delivered through a hybrid COIL format during UWC's second semester (July–November), Dr. Makhaya Malema and I will co-instruct shared synchronous seminars and manage asynchronous cross-cultural discussion boards.
- **Student Impact:** This connects UWC postgraduate scholars with JCSU undergraduates, culminating in joint student-produced policy briefs, providing high-impact global exchange for minority students who often lack traditional study-abroad access.

5. Project Implementation

The timeline is explicitly structured to ensure pre-departure regulatory clearance and maximize in-country data collection during the 6-month grant period.

Phase 1: Pre-Departure & Regulatory Clearance (Jan–June 2027)

- Initiate reciprocal IRB protocol submission and UWC Research Ethics Committee (REC) clearance.

- Pre-test survey instruments; configure the Canvas/COIL digital platforms with Dr. Malema.

Phase 2: In-Country Fulbright Execution (July–Dec 2027, Cape Town)

- **July–Sept:** Arrive at UWC. Launch 6-week transatlantic COIL delivery linking SPM 435 and SRE 743. Front-load primary fieldwork (interviews, surveys, and PS4L focus groups).
- **Oct:** Transcribe interviews and execute qualitative/quantitative data coding (NVivo/SPSS) during South Africa's national examination lockdown period.
- **Nov–Dec:** Host stakeholder synthesis workshops with Cape Town sport leaders; deliver a UWC departmental seminar; draft the executive policy briefs.

Phase 3: Post-Grant Dissemination (Jan–April 2028, JCSU)

- Finalize co-authored journal submissions; present at international conferences; formalize the permanent JCSU-UWC institutional exchange Memorandum of Understanding (MoU).

6. Preparation and Host Institution Engagement

My extensive expertise in sport sociology, policy analysis, and cross-cultural research at an HBCU inherently prepares me to engage with an HDI in an institutional peer capacity. Furthermore, presenting my research at the World Association for Sport Management (WASM) Conference in South Africa helped me develop the cultural humility and professional networks required to operate effectively in Cape Town.

I have already established a deep preliminary alignment with Dr. Makhaya Malema and the SRES faculty at UWC. Together, we have plotted the timeline for dual-institutional ethics clearance to ensure fieldwork and COIL delivery commence immediately upon my arrival.

Beyond the classroom, I will integrate into UWC's academic life by delivering guest colloquia on U.S. HBCU athletic models, facilitating research roundtables for UWC Master's and Ph.D. candidates, and collaborating with SRES curriculum committees.

7. Deliverables, Outcomes, and Impact

This project will produce 6 specific deliverables mapped across academic, pedagogical, and community impact:

Academic & Research Deliverables

1. **Peer-Reviewed Publications:** Co-author two empirical articles with Dr. Malema targeting top-tier journals (e.g., *Journal of Sport Management*, *International Review for the Sociology of Sport*).
2. **Comparative Policy White Paper:** Publish an open-access monograph evaluating post-apartheid and post-civil rights sport policy frameworks, intended for regional sport governing bodies in both the Western Cape and North Carolina.

Pedagogical & Institutional Deliverables

1. **Institutionalized COIL Curriculum:** Establish a permanent, reusable 6-week transatlantic virtual exchange framework for JCSU and UWC that can be sustained annually without requiring continuous external grant funding.
2. **Formal Memorandum of Understanding (MoU):** Establish the administrative foundation for an MoU between JCSU and UWC to facilitate ongoing faculty exchanges, student study abroad, and joint postgraduate advising.

Community & Civic Deliverables

1. **Community Sport Equity Toolkit:** Co-develop an actionable, non-academic evaluation toolkit for Play Sport4Life (PS4L) and Cape Flats civic organizers to assess program reach, coach development, and equitable facility allocation.
2. **Cross-Continental Urban Sport Initiative:** Utilize pilot findings to launch a broader comparative research pipeline connecting Charlotte's urban sports ecosystem with Cape Flats community development programs for future external grant funding.

8. Conclusion

This Fulbright project provides reciprocal, long-term institutional value. For JCSU, it globalizes the sport management curriculum and establishes the university as a leader in international comparative sport research. For UWC, it deepens the SRES department's global reach by connecting South African scholars with U.S. collegiate athletic governance models.

Ultimately, the relationships built and the data gathered will serve as the pilot foundation for multi-institutional grant applications, ensuring that this transatlantic partnership continues to advance social equity through sport long after the grant period concludes.